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Exploratory analysis of the Visa Bulletin

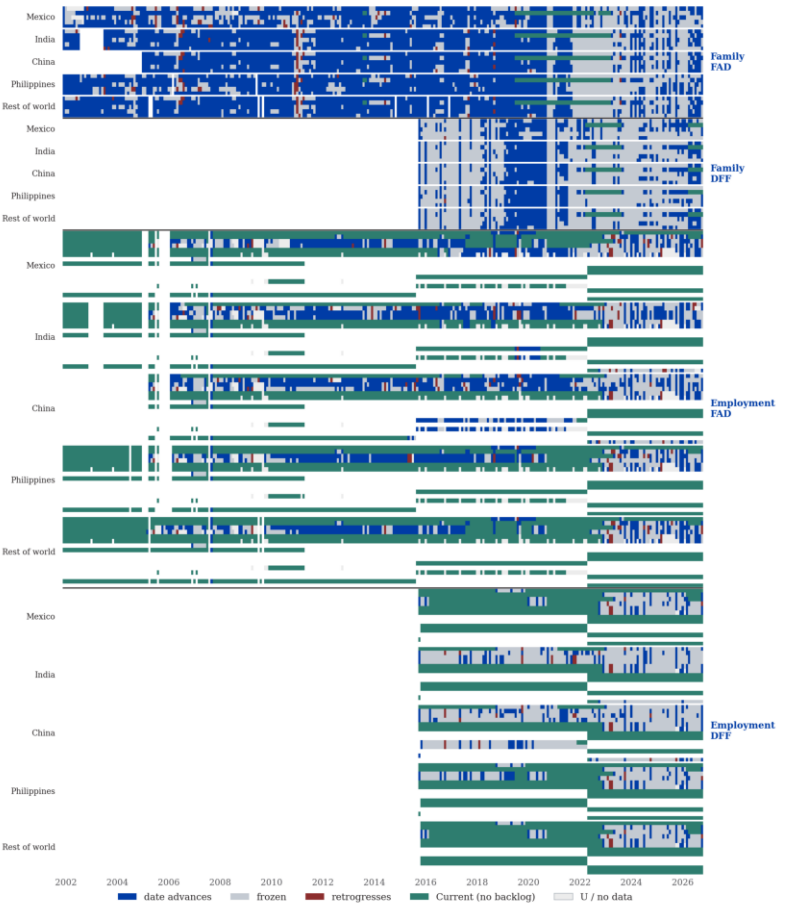
The United States visa queue, measured month by month since 2001

Automated report generated with the October 2026 bulletin — rebuilt with every new bulletin.

28,061	194	299/299	58%
monthly observations	country × cat. × table series	bulletins since Dec 2001	months with a date (F)

28,061 months in line, in a single image

Each row is one country × category × table series (194 series); each cell, a monthly bulletin. In 45% of months with a date the line did not move.



Source: U.S. Department of State, Visa Bulletin (Dec 2001 – October 2026). White = the series does not exist that month (e.g., DFF before 2015).

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Six findings on one page

All derived from this cut's statistical census; none written by hand.

45%

of the months with a date, the queue did NOT move — freezing is the system's dominant behavior and the real yardstick for any forecast.

2.4%

of the movements are setbacks (389 recorded retrogressions); rare, but of up to 12.8 years in a single month.

25 years

is today's longest wait (Mexico F4); no family series waits less than 0.

71/74

evaluable series demand differencing (ADF and KPSS agree): the panel is integrated of order 1, with no stationary exceptions.

0–21 days

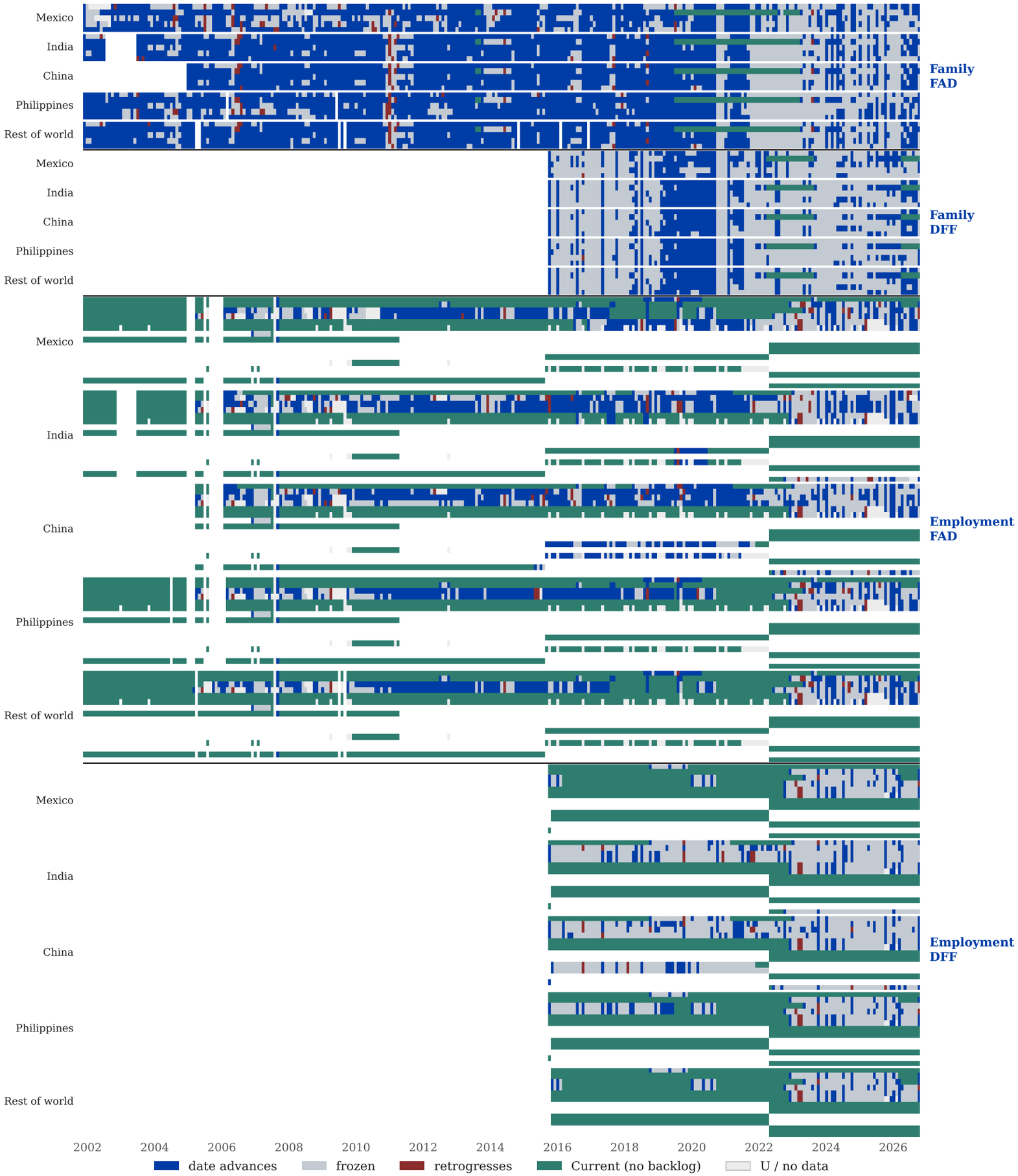
is the range of the median advance per calendar month: fiscal-year seasonality is weak and not exploitable.

74 of 194

structural series are fully evaluable (tiered coverage; 136 have at least one date).

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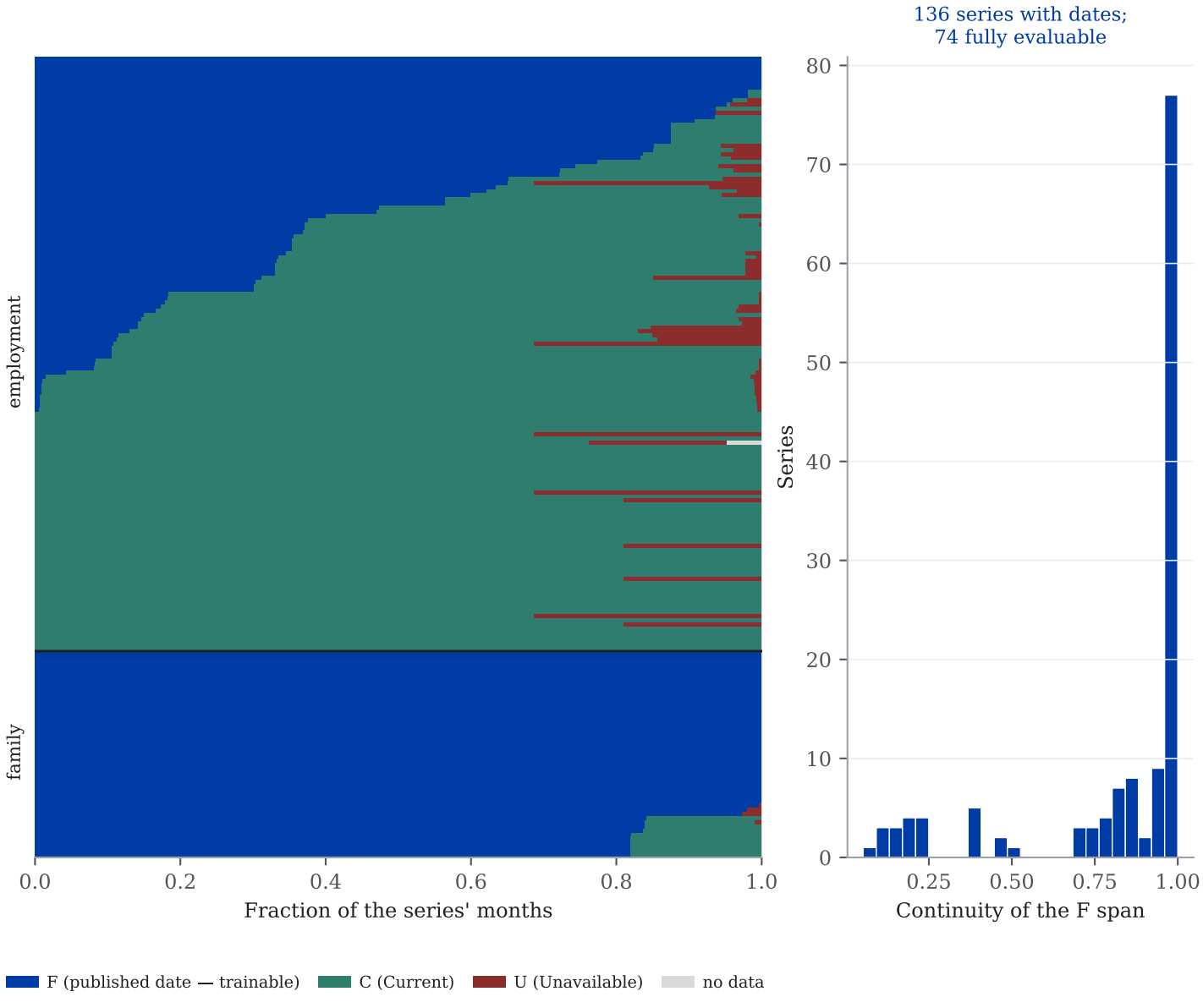


Source: U.S. Department of State, Visa Bulletin (Dec 2001 – October 2026). White = the series does not exist that month (e.g., DFF before 2015).

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58% of the panel is trainable — and censused series by series

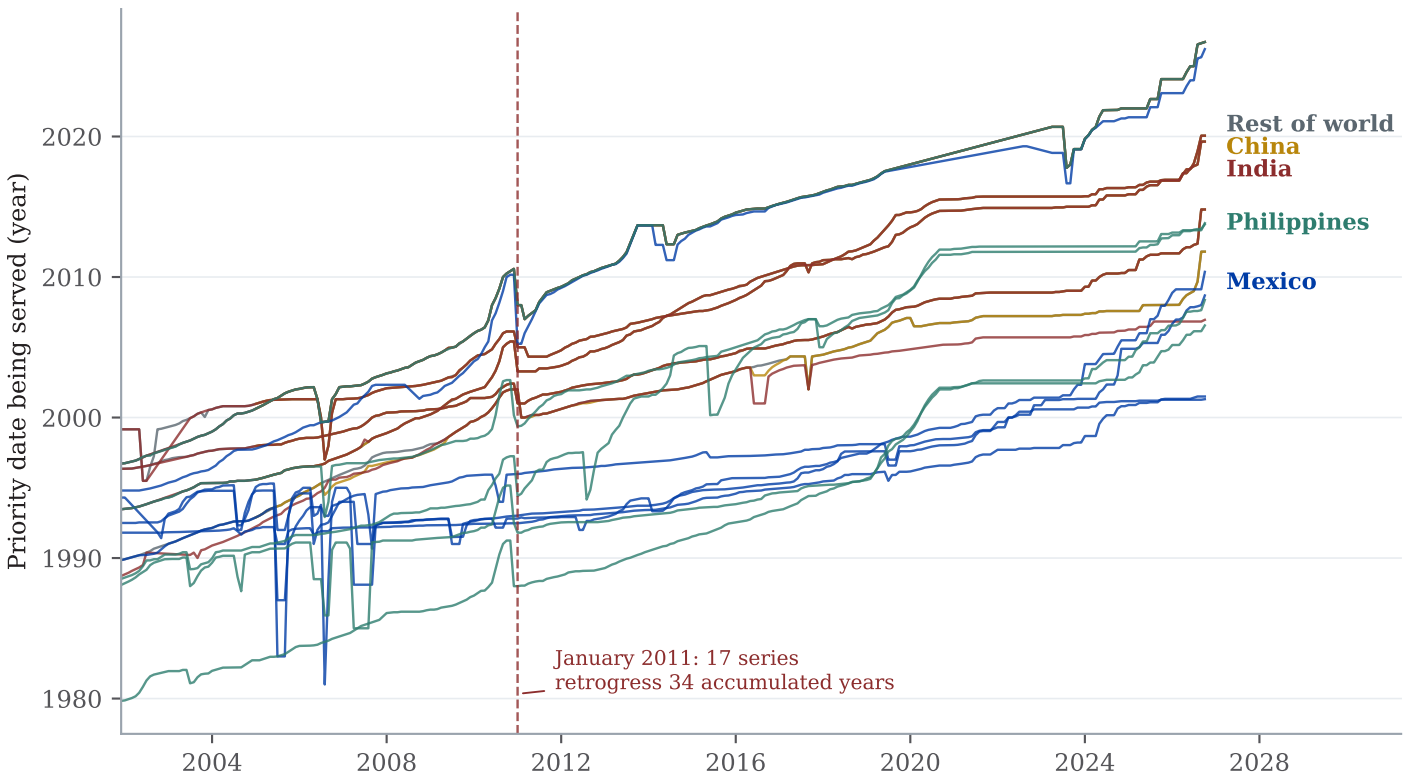
Regime composition of the 194 structural series (left, sorted by % of dates within each block) and continuity of the dated span (right).



Source: U.S. Department of State, Visa Bulletin (Dec 2001 – October 2026). Tiered coverage: structural → with dates → evaluable.

A quarter century in line, series by series

Trajectories of the 25 family series (FAD). The median advance is 21 days per month: the line almost never runs, and sometimes moves backwards.

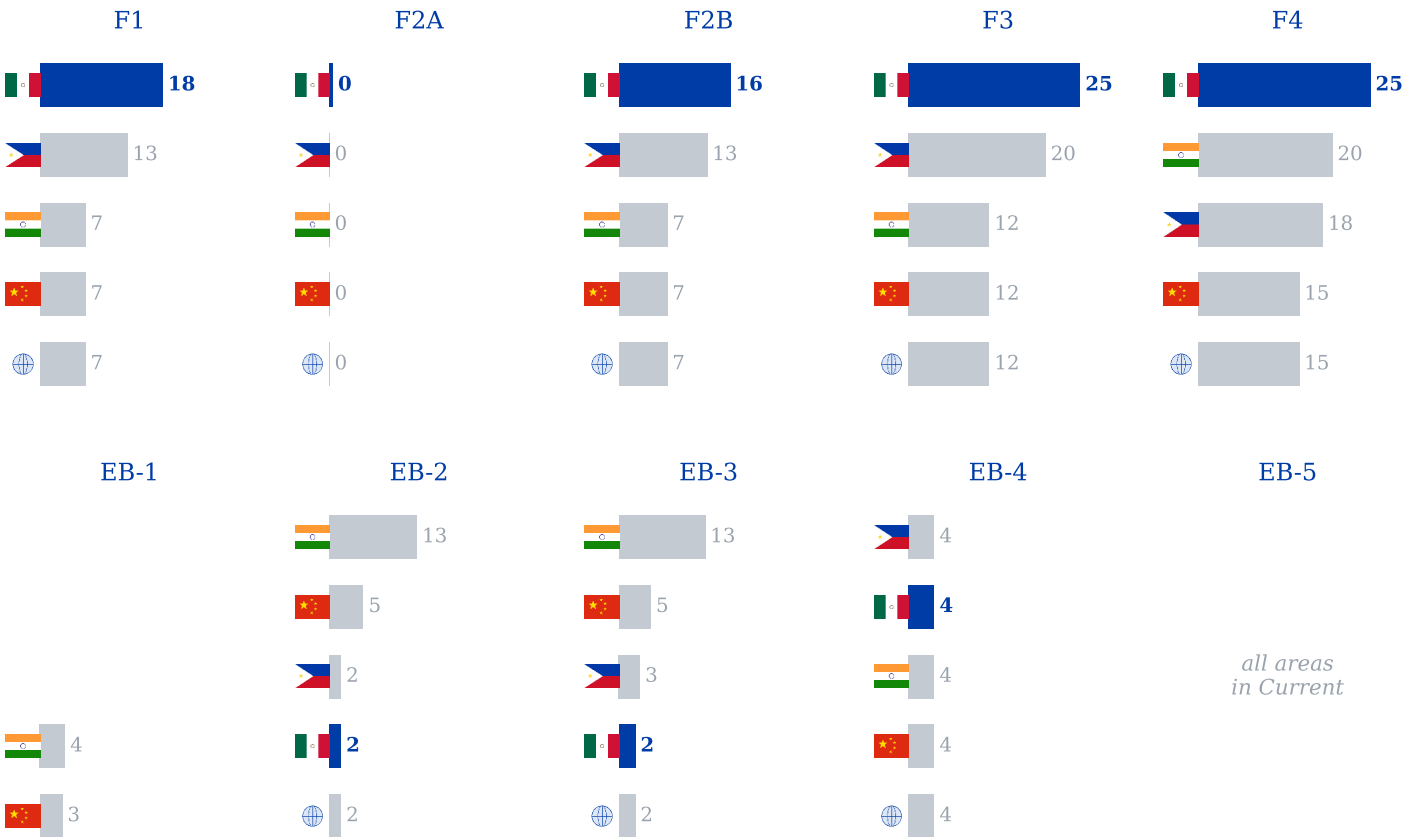


Source: U.S. Department of State, Visa Bulletin (Dec 2001 – October 2026).

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Mexico F4 waits 25 years; India EB-2, 13

Current backlog in years (FAD) by category and chargeability area; Mexico highlighted. Areas in Current (no backlog) do not appear.

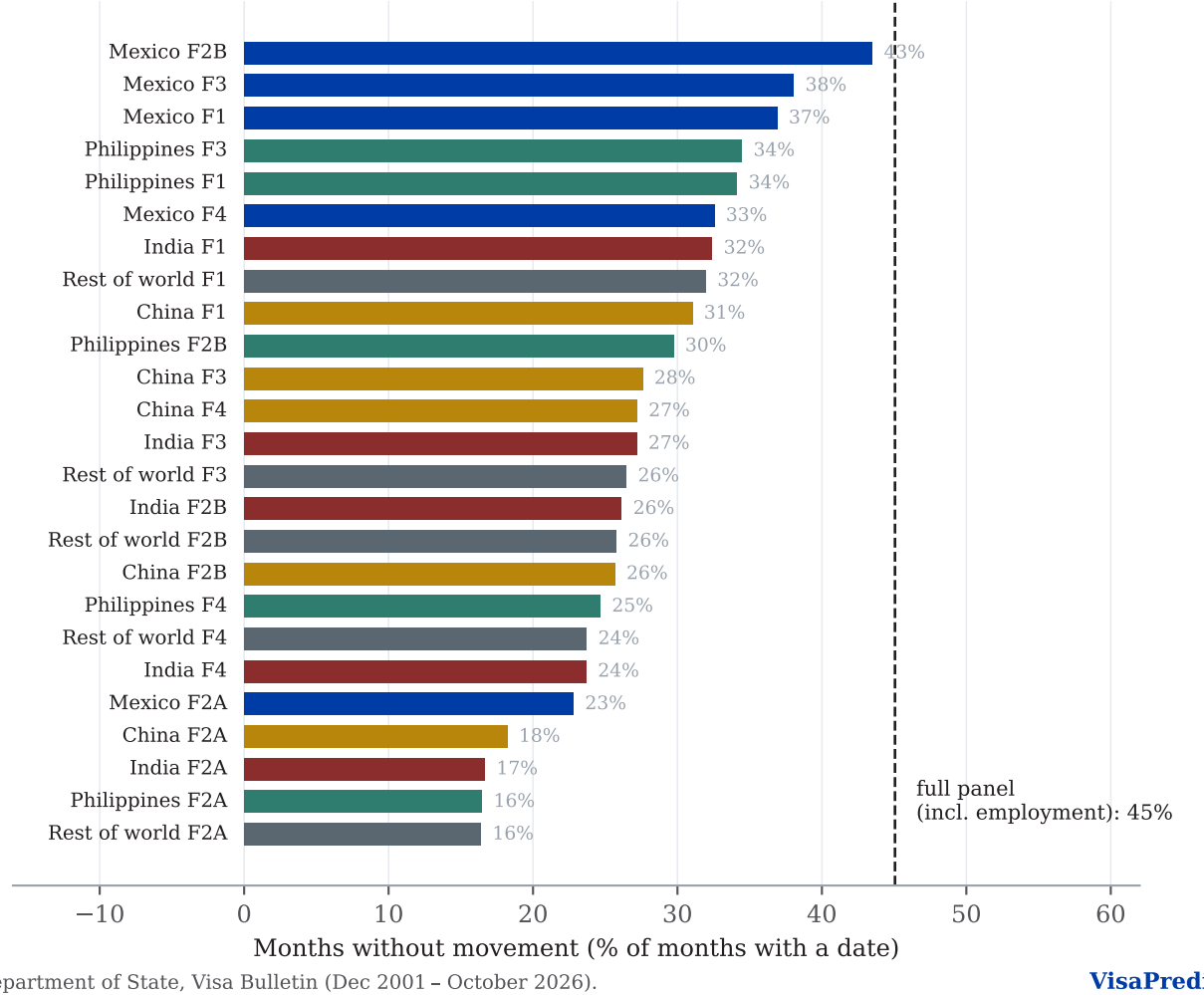


Source: U.S. Department of State, Visa Bulletin (Dec 2001 – October 2026). Backlog = bulletin month − current priority date.

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The typical family series spends 27% of its months frozen

Percentage of months in which the date did not move (family FAD series). It is the reason the naïve forecast is so hard to beat.

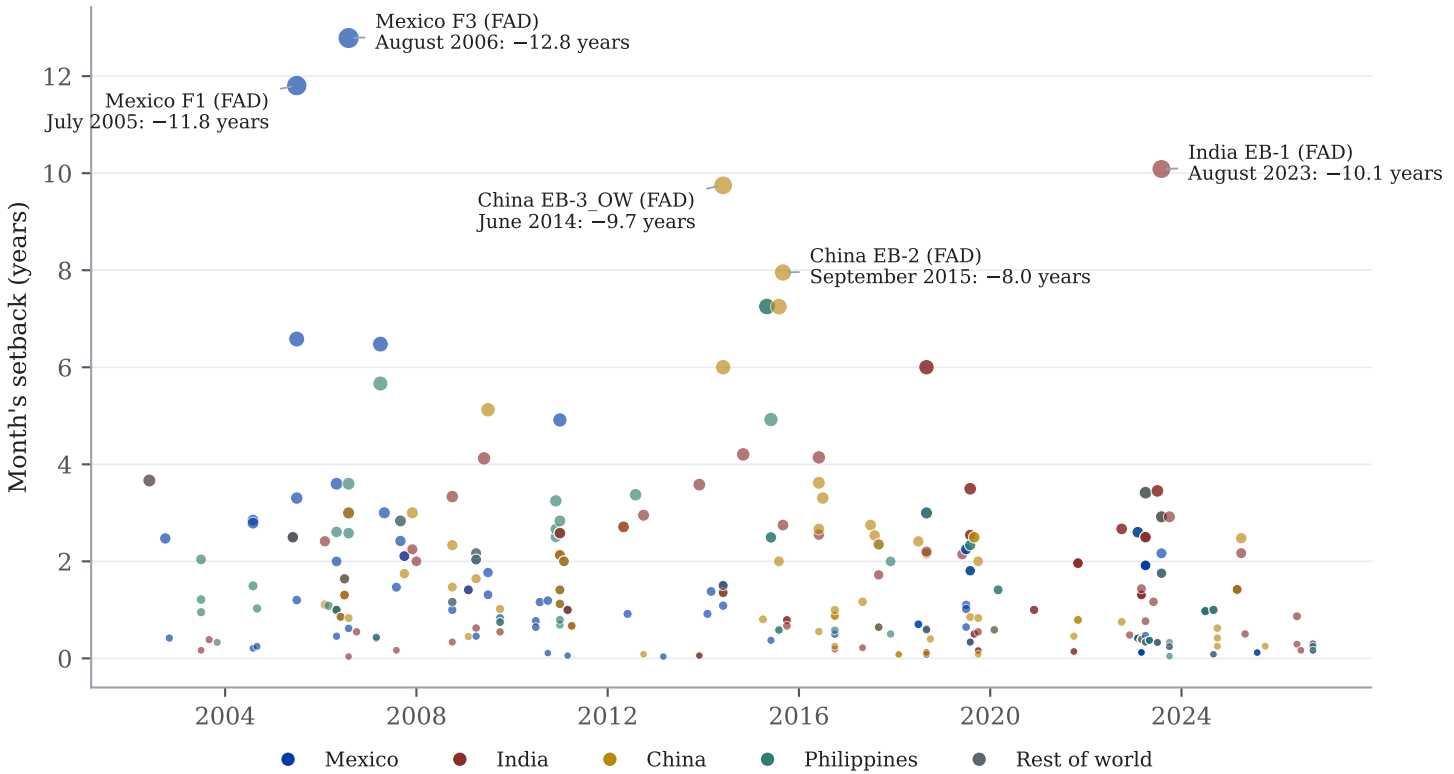


Source: U.S. Department of State, Visa Bulletin (Dec 2001 – October 2026).

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389 times the line moved backwards — and a few were earthquakes

Each dot is a month of retrogression in one of the series (2.4% of observed movements); size is proportional to the setback.

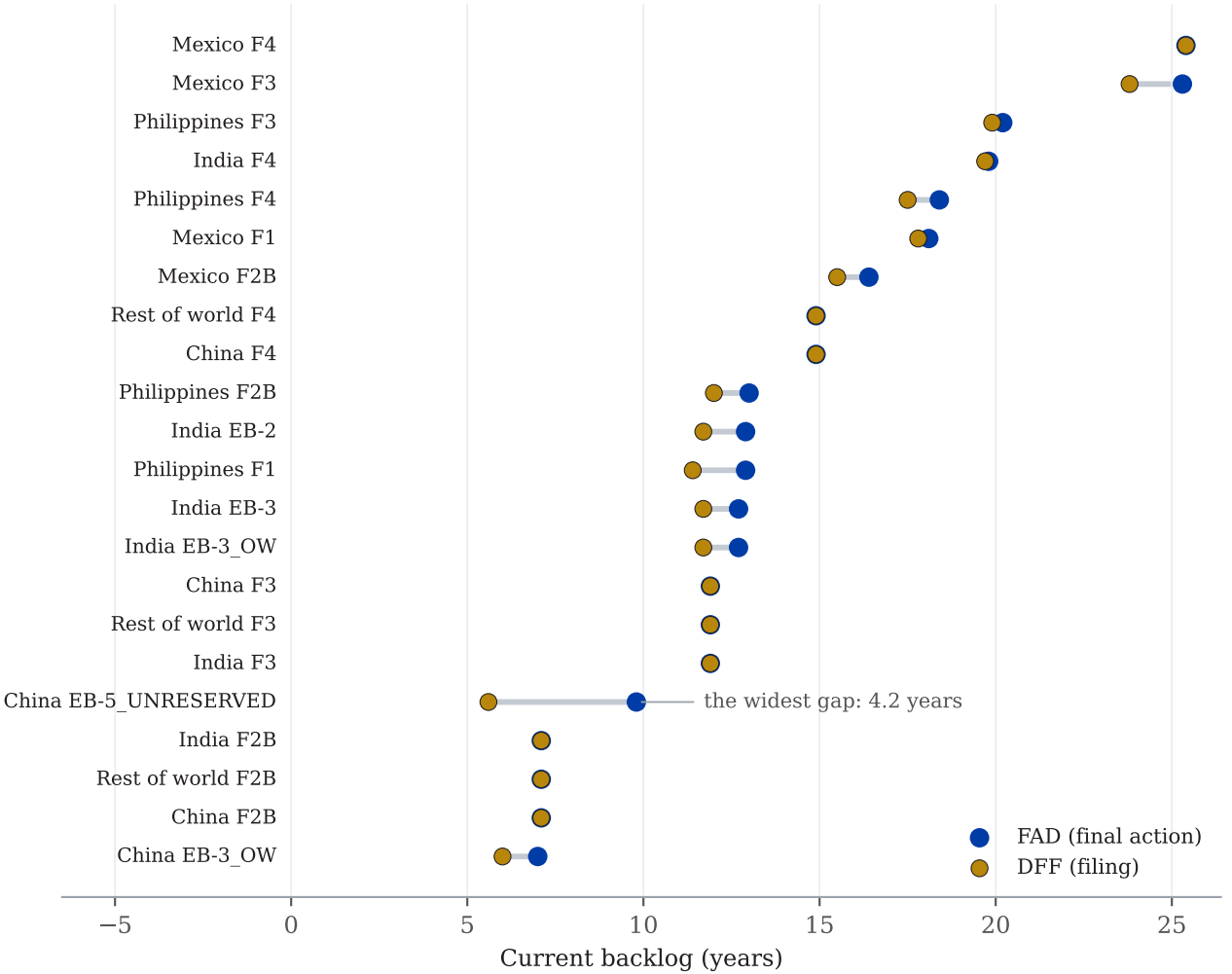


Source: U.S. Department of State, Visa Bulletin (Dec 2001 – October 2026).

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Filing 12 months earlier: that is what the DFF table is worth

Current backlog per series depending on the table you look at: final action (FAD) always trails the filing calendar (DFF).

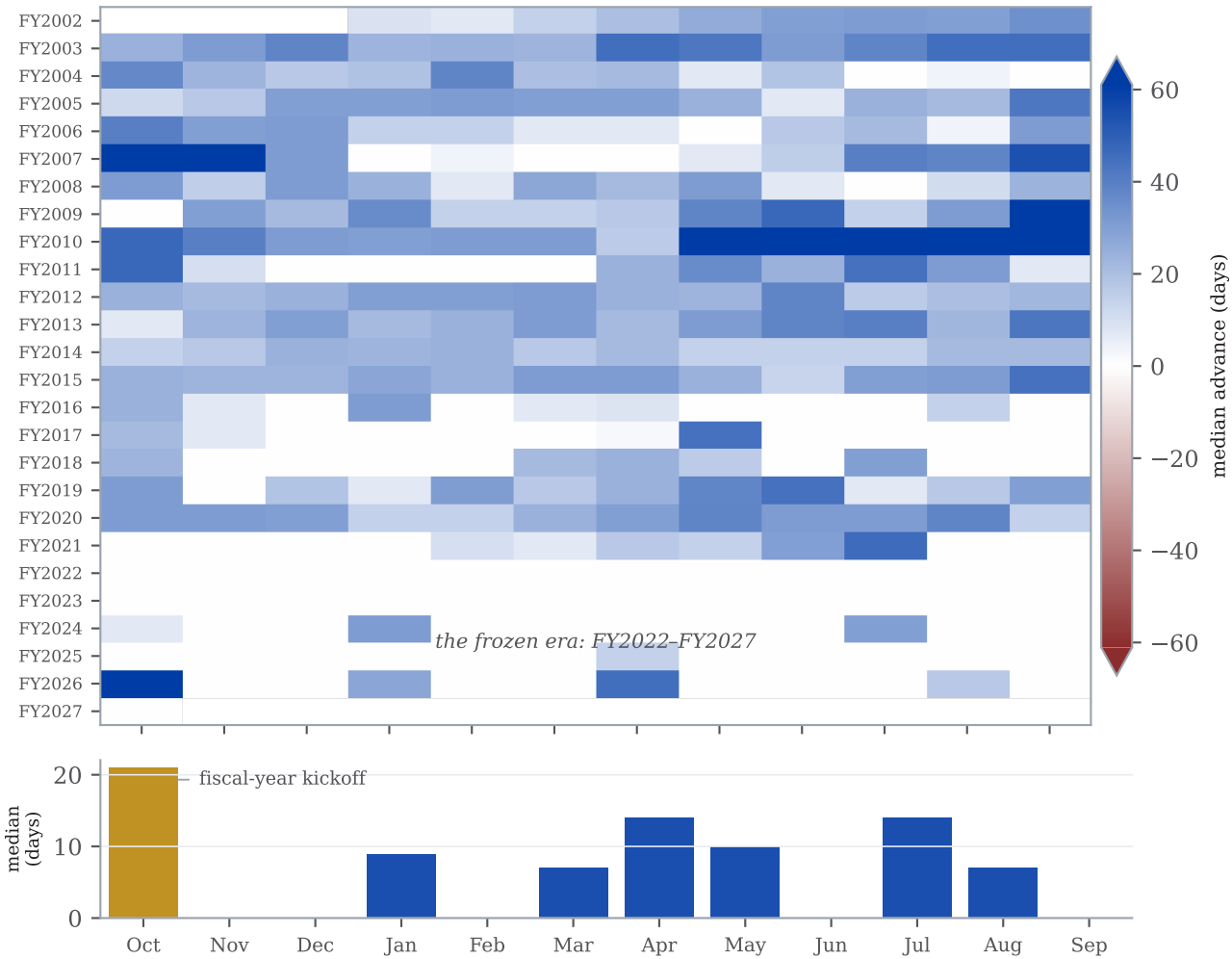


Source: U.S. Department of State, Visa Bulletin (Dec 2001 – October 2026). Series with both tables published today.

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The fiscal year barely has a pulse: the typical month advances between 0 and 21 days

Median advance of the full panel by month (columns in fiscal-year order, October first) and by fiscal year (rows). There is no exploitable seasonality — a finding, not a shortcoming.

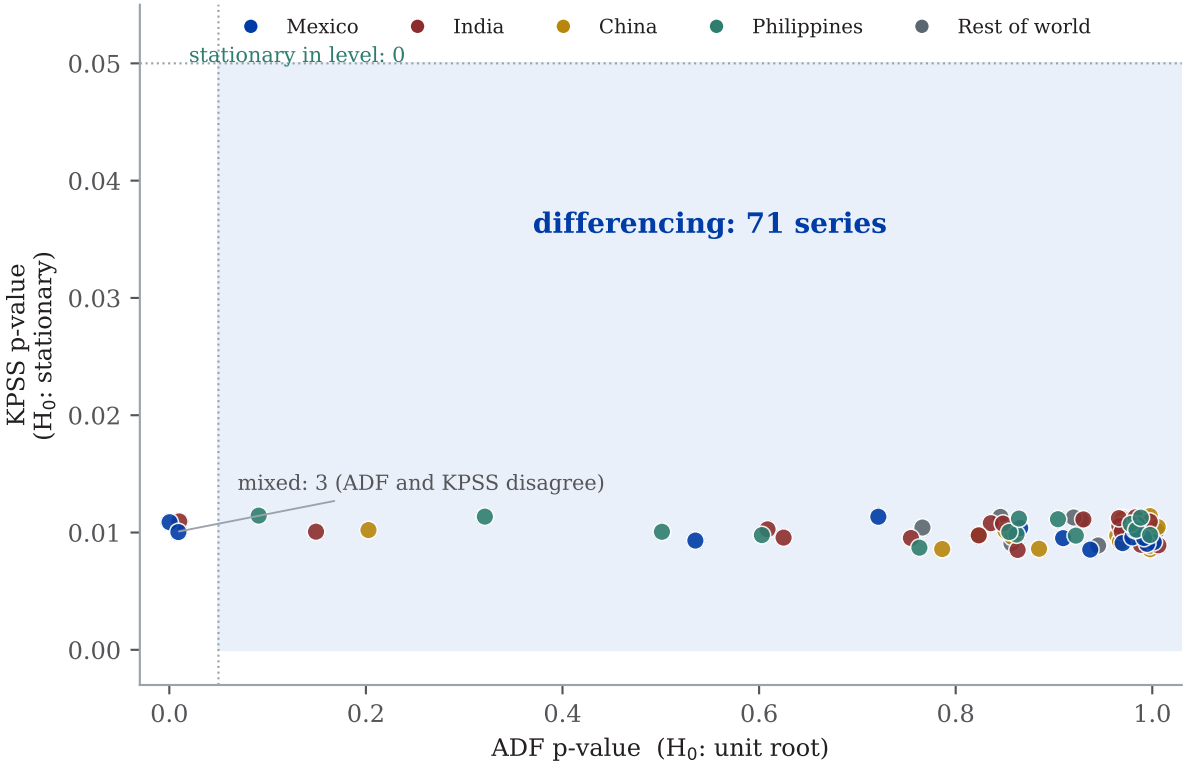


Source: U.S. Department of State, Visa Bulletin (Dec 2001 – October 2026). Color scale clipped at the 98th percentile.

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71 of 74 evaluable series demand differencing

ADF and KPSS agree: the panel is integrated of order 1. No series is stationary in level; the KPSS axis is clipped to its saturation zone (p≤0.05).

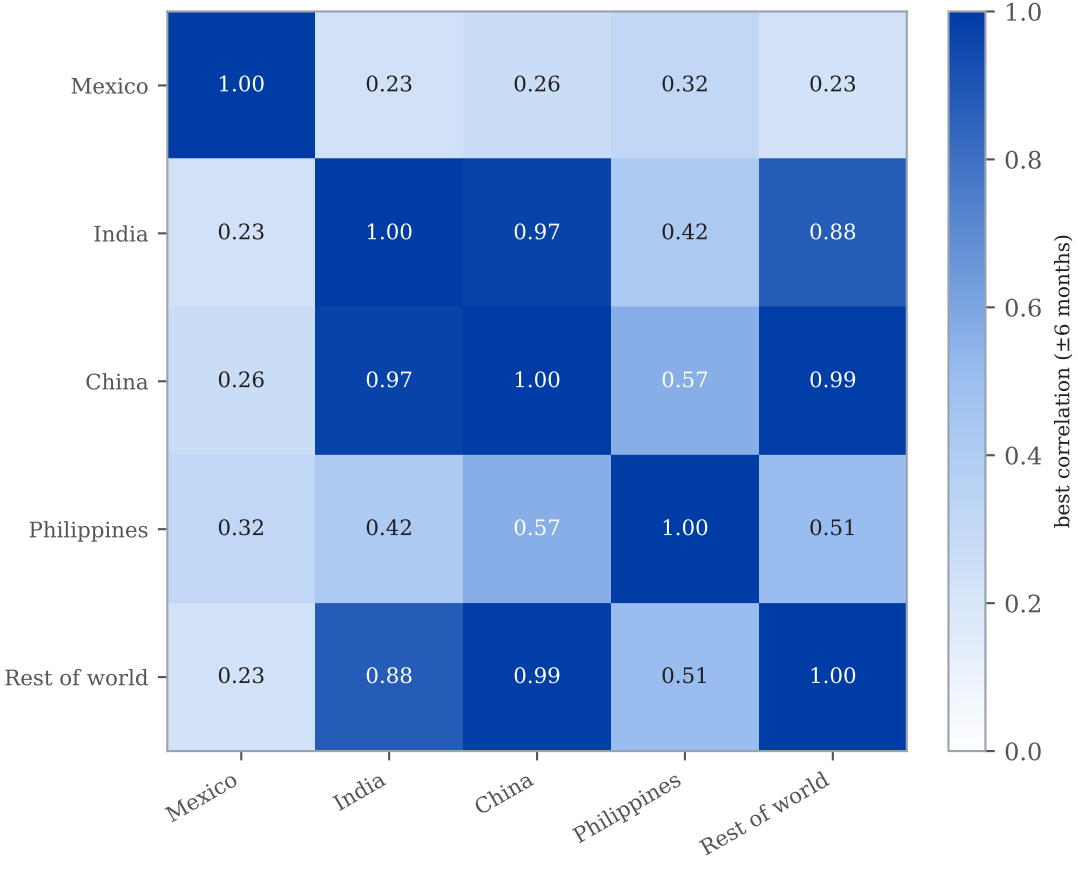


Source: U.S. Department of State, Visa Bulletin (Dec 2001 – October 2026). Slight jitter: the p-values saturate at the edges.

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Only 5 pairs of areas move hand in hand

Best cross-correlation of the advances (family FAD, lags of ±6 months). In ALL pairs the best lag is 0: co-movement is contemporaneous — no one leads anyone. The heterogeneity justifies modeling each series.

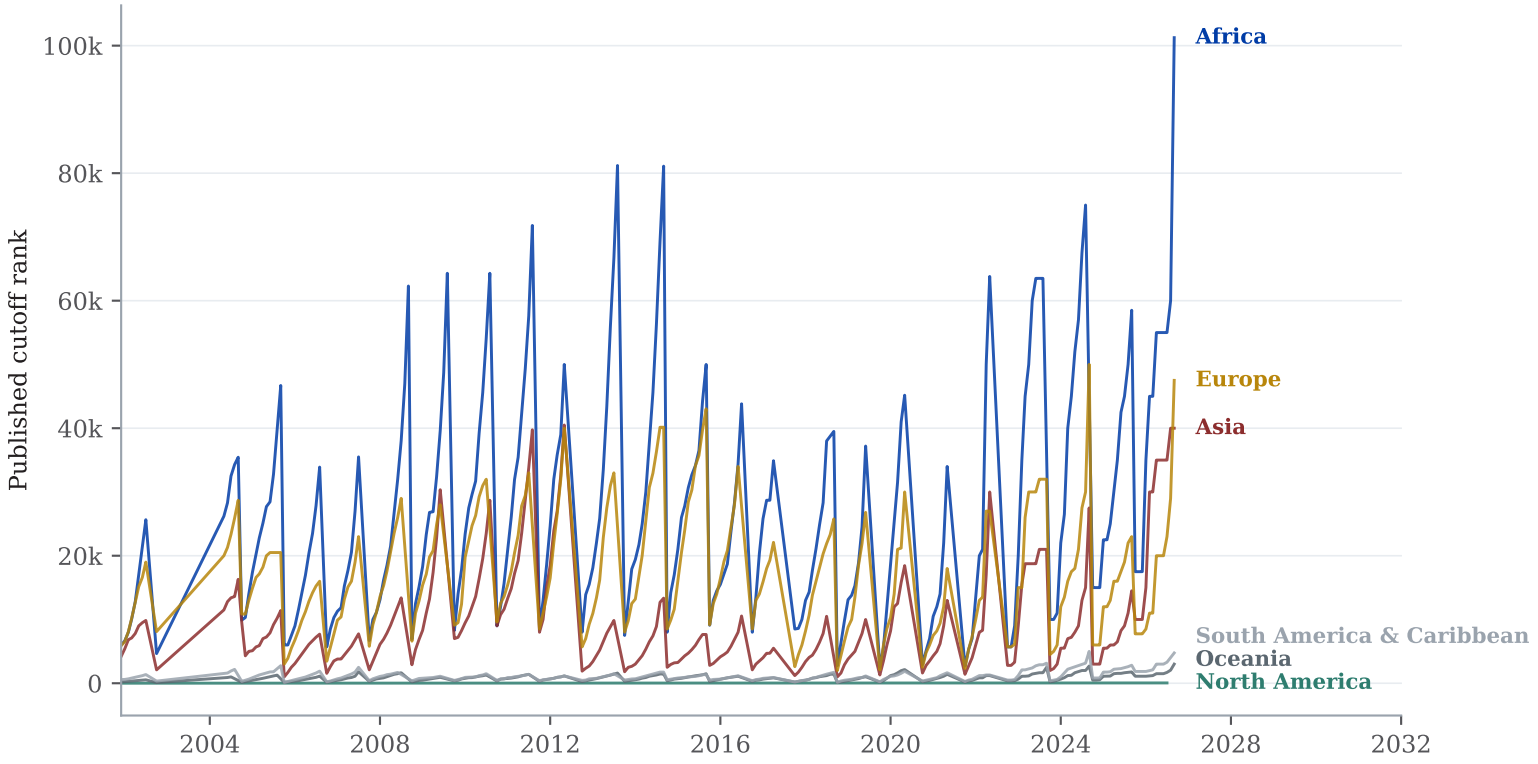


Source: U.S. Department of State, Visa Bulletin (Dec 2001 – October 2026).

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The lottery waits in line too: Africa cuts at 101k

Diversity-lottery cutoff rank by region (1,659 observations). It is a lottery NUMBER, not a date: a separate descriptive fact, outside the predictive target.



Source: U.S. Department of State, Visa Bulletin (Dec 2001 – October 2026). The sawtooth is the fiscal-year cycle: the cutoff climbs and resets.

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Methodological notes and lineage

Source and panel

U.S. Department of State, Visa Bulletin (2001-12 → 2026-10). Multiseries panel y(p,c,b,t): 28,061 rows, 194 structural series, 299 bulletins (100% coverage). Target variable: days since the 1-Jan-1975 base epoch, only months with a published date (state F).

Cell regimes

F = published date (the predictive target) · C = Current, no backlog · U = Unavailable · UNK = no data. C/U/UNK are kept as descriptive annotation; they are never interpolated or scored.

Statistical census

Per series: length, continuity, gaps, retrogressions, freezing and median advance. On the evaluable series: ADF, KPSS and DF-GLS (stationarity), Ljung-Box (autocorrelation) and the ARCH test (heteroskedasticity) on the increments.

Tiered coverage

Structural (194) → with dates (136) → fully evaluable (74, ≥84 F obs and enough span for the walk-forward). The diversity lottery (DV) is a separate descriptive fact: regional ranks, not dates, outside the predictive target.

Reproducibility

Generated by experiments/build_eda_facts.py + make_gallery_figures.py + build_eda_report.py (make eda-all && make eda-report) in the public pipeline github.com/UACJ-MIAAD/VisaPredictAI. It is rebuilt automatically with every new bulletin; the figures are validated against the single source of truth key_facts.json in continuous integration.

Notice

Academic, demonstrative document (UACJ · MIAAD). It is not immigration advice nor an official prediction.